

Observer Effect Roleplay Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 30-40 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	observer-effect-roleplay

Big idea: In human sciences, observation can become part of the situation being observed.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Task: build the tallest paper tower in five minutes while observers visibly tally leadership, interruptions, and suggestions. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Second round: observers sit farther away and use a simpler tally scheme. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Observer Effect Roleplay Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Second round: observers sit farther away and use a simpler tally scheme. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — In human sciences, observation can become part of the situation being observed.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can observation alter what is known?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Task: build the tallest paper tower in five minutes while observers visibly tally leadership, interruptions, and suggestions.
- Second round: observers sit farther away and use a simpler tally scheme.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Activity Steps

1. Assign some students to perform a simple group task and others to observe.
2. Run one round with obvious observation and one with a less intrusive method.
3. Observers tally behavior using a fixed coding scheme.
4. Participants reflect on whether observation changed how they acted.
5. Debrief validity, ethics, and method choice.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can human behavior be observed without changing it?
- How should researchers balance natural behavior, consent, and control?
- What counts as good evidence when people react to being studied?

Knowledge Questions

- Can observation alter what is known?
- How do ethics shape methods in human sciences?
- What makes behavioral evidence reliable?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with participants change behaviour when a researcher, teacher, or peer observer is present. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...